CT-KAE on transonic flow: reference and back001

28 October 2026

Models

Both are the same continuous-time Koopman autoencoder. A CNN encoder maps two input frames ($\Delta t = 0.1$) and the Mach number to $z \in \mathbb{R}^{256}$. The latent evolves exactly linearly, $z(\tau) = e^{\tau A(\mathrm{Ma})} z_0$, with A block-diagonal: 128 damped oscillators, decay $\gamma \geq 0$. A FiLM-conditioned CNN decoder maps z back to the four fields. 24.7 M parameters; trained 20k steps on the 33 training simulations to reconstruct and to predict 8 frames ahead, with latent consistency. **back001** adds backward latent consistency at weight 0.01. Three seeds each; every number below is a mean over seeds or a 3-seed average, as stated.

Main results

Table 1: Forecasting (MSE $\times 10^{-3}$, all frames; LSiM $\times 10^{-1}$), data assimilation (relative L_2 of the analysis at t_0; df1 headline: 12 problems, 2000 iterations; sweeps: mean over the points of six sweeps that every method was run on, 31 at $\delta_f = 1$ and 37 at $\delta_f = 9$), and inference cost (Tra_long, 240 steps, batch 1, RTX 4090). Lower is better throughout. Post-processing is described in the next section; its effect on DA is in Table 3. Original KAE: final checkpoint; the published DA numbers used a checkpoint selected on the DA test set.

	MSE			LSiM			DA error			ms per
	ext	int	long	ext	int	long	df1 head.	df1 sweeps	df9 sweeps	step
ACDM	2.14	2.92	22.63	1.29	1.38	3.83	0.006	0.049	0.258	142.47
U-Net$_{ut}$	1.60	1.48	22.18	1.09	0.95	3.81	0.215	0.208	0.270	6.66
U-Net$_{tn}$	1.37	1.77	22.38	1.05	1.05	3.92	–	–	–	7.06
Original KAE (final ckpt)	2.05	11.05	18.47	–	–	–	0.029	0.029	0.103	0.80
Reference	1.91	3.37	16.08	1.41	1.71	4.06	0.029	0.046	0.095	0.27
Reference + post-proc.	1.31	2.45	11.87	1.73	1.86	7.24	–	–	–	7.68
back001	2.03	3.04	15.11	1.49	1.71	4.88	0.024	0.031	0.088	0.27
back001 + post-proc.	1.46	2.46	11.97	1.90	1.81	7.47	–	–	–	7.68

- **Long rollouts:** at 240 steps both CT-KAEs have 27–47% lower MSE than ACDM and the U-Nets and 13–36% lower than the original KAE, and stay correlated with the truth over 1000 steps (Fig. 2).
- **Data assimilation:** both are at least 2× more accurate than the U-Net and FNO at every lead. ACDM + SDA wins at $\delta_f \leq 2$. Against the original KAE, back001 is equal at short leads and better from $\delta_f = 8$; the reference is worse at short leads (Fig. 1).
- **Short horizon:** with post-processing the reference is the best model on ext; the U-Nets remain best on int.
- **back001 vs reference:** back001 is better on DA, int and long, worse on ext. Post-processing removes most of the forecasting differences; the DA advantage remains.
- **LSiM** favours the baselines throughout, and post-processing makes it worse.

Post-processing

All steps act at inference on a trained model. Settings were fixed before the test sets were scored: mixture width and shrinkage on training rollouts, mirror averaging and the choice of steps on two proxy models trained with Mach 0.53–0.54 and 0.73–0.77 held out.

- **Mixture readout.** Average of 5 decodes of the same latent flow run at time scales $1 + \sigma\xi_q$ (Gauss–Hermite, $\sigma \approx 0.04$). Hedges the phase drift of the wake.
- **Mirror averaging.** The flow is (nearly) symmetric about the centre line: flip the input vertically with $v_y \to -v_y$, forecast, flip back, average with the plain forecast.
- **Climatology shrinkage.** Per lead and field, pull the forecast towards the Mach-interpolated training mean by a factor fitted on training rollouts. Affects long leads only.
- **Seed averaging.** Average the forecasts of three independently trained seeds.
- **Cost.** The full pipeline is 30 decodes per step: 7.7 ms per step against 0.27 for a single decode, about the cost of a U-Net and 18× cheaper than ACDM. Peak memory 0.9 GB.
- **Tested and rejected** on the proxies: test-time refinement of z_0 on the input frames (always worse), a mixture over neighbouring Mach numbers (no effect), lead-dependent mixture width, Wiener filtering by wavenumber (no better than one factor per lead and field).

Table 2: Each post-processing step added in turn: MSE $\times 10^{-3}$ (rows 1–4: mean over the 3 seeds; row 5: one 3-seed average), decoder calls per predicted step and wall clock per step.

		ext	int	long	decodes/step	ms/step
Reference	single decode	1.91	3.37	16.08	1	0.27
	+ mixture	1.77	3.16	13.03	5	1.28
	+ mirror	1.40	2.58	12.74	10	2.56
	+ shrinkage	1.40	2.58	11.98	10	2.56
	+ 3-seed average	1.31	2.45	11.87	30	7.68
back001	single decode	2.03	3.04	15.11	1	0.27
	+ mixture	1.88	2.89	13.45	5	1.28
	+ mirror	1.56	2.58	13.06	10	2.56
	+ shrinkage	1.56	2.57	12.07	10	2.56
	+ 3-seed average	1.46	2.46	11.97	30	7.68

In data assimilation only mirror averaging applies: 4D-Var is run once in the plain frame and once in the mirrored frame, and the two analyses are averaged. It cuts the analysis error by 10–16% for both models at twice the cost (Table 3).

Table 3: Mirror averaging in 4D-Var: analysis error, seed 2 of each model, same problems as Table 1.

		df1 head.	df1 sweeps	df9 sweeps
Reference	plain	0.030	0.047	0.098
	mirror	0.026	0.042	0.088
	change	-13%	-10%	-10%
back001	plain	0.024	0.032	0.092
	mirror	0.021	0.027	0.082
	change	-16%	-15%	-11%

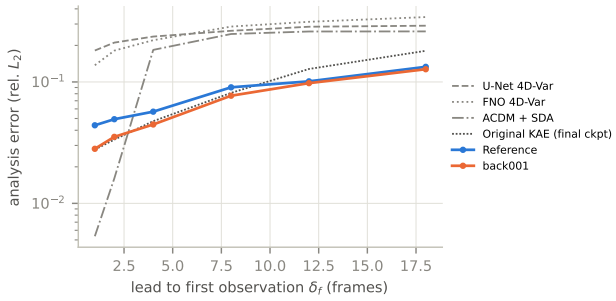


Figure 1: Analysis error against the lead δ_f to the first observation, transonic flow, $\delta_l = 25$, 5 observations, 500 iterations, 8 problems per point.

The paper's transonic experiments, re-run

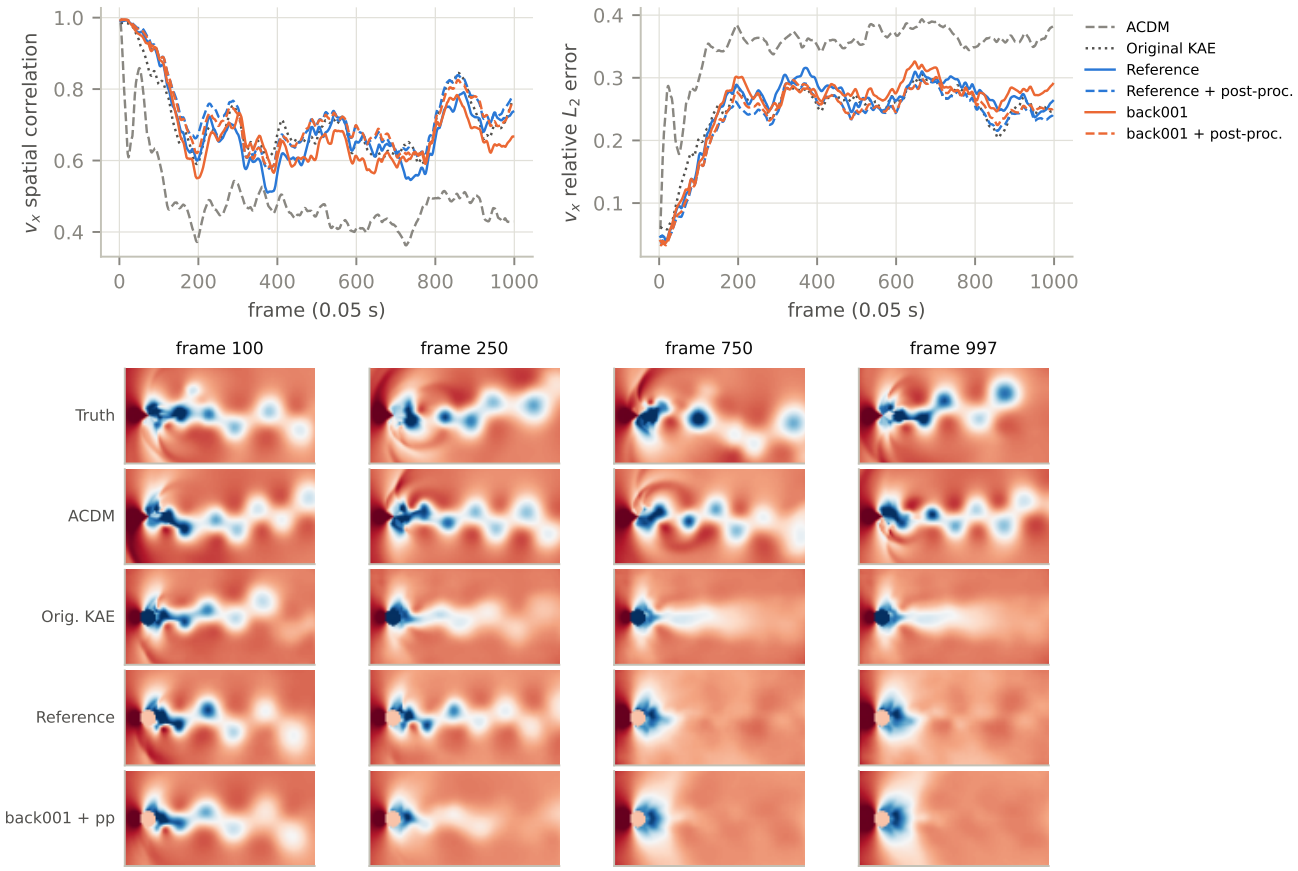


Figure 2: 1000-step rollout (Tra_long simulations, 0.05 s per frame, 2 trajectories). Top: v_x spatial correlation and relative L_2 error per frame. Bottom: pressure, first trajectory. Post-processing here is the 3-seed average of mixture + mirror, without shrinkage.

Findings.

- **Integrators.** RK4 matches the exact exponential up to $\Delta t = 0.3$; explicit Euler diverges on long rollouts (from $\Delta t = 0.05$ for back001), as the oscillators are almost undamped.
- **Unseen time step.** Forecasts between the training time steps are as accurate as on them (Table 5).
- **Spectra.** The CT-KAE spectra are too shallow and its band errors are 3–7× those of ACDM and the U-Net (but well below FNO's on long rollouts); post-processing worsens them. The CT-KAE's MSE advantage on long rollouts comes from tracking phase, not from resolving small scales.
- **Not re-run:** the original KAE's loss and LoRA ablations need retraining; the CT-KAE's own ablation study (in the full report) replaces them.

Table 4: The latent ODE $\dot{y} = Ay$ integrated numerically instead of $e^{\tau A}$ (seed 0, single decode). MSE $\times 10^{-3}$.

	integrator	ext	int	long
Reference	$e^{\tau A}$ (exact)	1.61	3.32	16.66
Reference	RK4, $\Delta t = 0.1$	1.61	3.32	16.66
Reference	RK4, $\Delta t = 0.3$	1.63	3.28	16.34
Reference	RK4, $\Delta t = 0.5$	1.92	3.22	14.58
Reference	midpoint, $\Delta t = 0.1$	1.77	3.49	17.10
Reference	Euler, $\Delta t = 0.05$	2.28	3.76	24.82
Reference	Euler, $\Delta t = 0.1$	6.94	6.11	diverged
Reference	Dopri5 (adaptive)	1.61	3.32	16.66
back001	$e^{\tau A}$ (exact)	1.98	2.91	14.57
back001	RK4, $\Delta t = 0.1$	1.98	2.91	14.57
back001	RK4, $\Delta t = 0.3$	2.00	2.90	14.46
back001	RK4, $\Delta t = 0.5$	2.29	2.97	14.17
back001	midpoint, $\Delta t = 0.1$	2.02	3.01	14.71
back001	Euler, $\Delta t = 0.05$	2.61	3.71	diverged
back001	Euler, $\Delta t = 0.1$	8.81	12.37	diverged
back001	Dopri5 (adaptive)	1.98	2.91	14.57

Table 5: Unseen time step: MSE at leads on the training grid (0.1 s) and at the half-steps between them (0.05 s, never trained on). Mean over 3 seeds.

	ext		int	
	0.1	0.05	0.1	0.05
Reference	1.98	1.99	3.49	3.51
back001	2.10	2.11	3.14	3.16

Table 6: Spectrum of $|v|$: relative error in the low ($k \leq 4$), mid (5–12) and high (13–32) wavenumber bands and the fitted mid-band slope.

	Tra_int (60 steps)				Tra_long (240 steps)			
	low	mid	high	slope	low	mid	high	slope
ACDM	0.03	0.02	0.04	-3.30	0.06	0.11	0.04	-3.27
U-Net$_{ut}$	0.03	0.02	0.02	-3.31	0.05	0.08	0.03	-3.38
FNO$_{16}$	0.09	0.14	0.27	-3.37	0.76	0.78	0.82	-3.56
Reference	0.20	0.09	0.11	-2.87	0.31	0.34	0.20	-2.53
Reference + post-proc.	0.20	0.19	0.25	-2.96	0.42	0.57	0.47	-2.36
back001	0.19	0.09	0.12	-2.96	0.28	0.41	0.24	-2.41
back001 + post-proc.	0.20	0.18	0.23	-3.00	0.41	0.58	0.46	-2.37
Ground truth				-3.30				-3.30

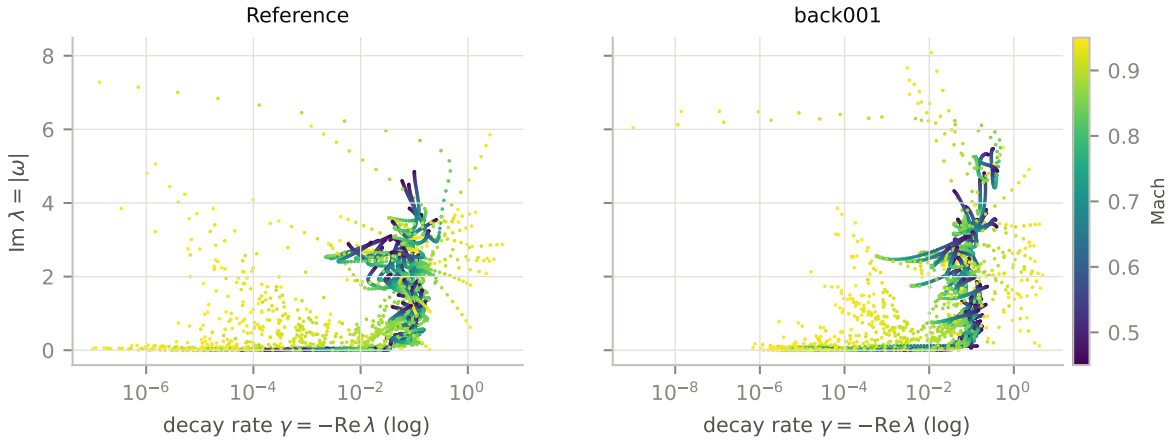


Figure 3: Generator eigenvalues $\lambda = -\gamma \pm i\omega$ for Mach 0.45–0.95 (seed 0).